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Music Terms Flashcards — Set 2

For undergraduate music & piano majors

38 TERMS · TERM — DEFINITION

TEMPO

grave — Very slow, solemn; slower and more serious than largo.

largo — Broad, stately slow tempo (roughly 40–60 bpm).

larghetto — Slightly faster than largo; fairly slow but less heavy.

adagio — Slow and stately; "at ease" (roughly 66–76 bpm).

andante — "Walking pace"; moderately slow, flowing (roughly 76–108 bpm).

moderato — At a moderate speed (roughly 108–120 bpm).

allegretto — Fairly quick; a little slower and lighter than allegro.

presto — Very fast (roughly 168–200 bpm or faster).

cédez — "Yield": gradually slow the music down; the French equivalent of ritardando.

retenu — Held back; a sudden holding of the tempo, like ritenuto.

en pressant — Hurrying forward; gradually speeding up, like accelerando.

pressez — Hurry; press on and increase the tempo.

au mouvement — "At the tempo": return to the original tempo; the French equivalent of a tempo.

au premier mouvement — "At the first tempo": return to the opening tempo.

DYNAMICS

dal niente — From nothing; the sound emerges gradually out of silence.

al niente — To nothing; fading away until the sound disappears.

mezza voce — In a "half voice"; subdued and restrained in tone.

una corda *(u.c.)* — "One string": press the soft pedal; the hammers strike fewer strings, giving a softer, veiled tone.

tre corde *(t.c.)* — "Three strings": release the soft pedal, returning to the full, normal tone.

senza sordino — "Without dampers": play with the dampers raised off the strings (sustain pedal down).

con sordino — "With dampers": the dampers rest on the strings; the normal piano sound.

sforzando piano *(sfp)* — A sudden strong accent followed at once by soft playing.

subito piano — Suddenly soft.

subito forte — Suddenly loud.

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EXPRESSION

dolce — Sweetly, tenderly.

espressivo — With expression; bring out the feeling of the phrase.

giocoso — Playfully, merrily.

risoluto — Resolutely, with bold determination.

misterioso — Mysteriously; with an enigmatic, veiled character.

tranquillo — Calmly, peacefully.

cantabile — In a singing style; let the line sing like a voice.

grazioso — Gracefully, elegantly.

pesante — Heavily; with a weighty, ponderous character.

affettuoso — Affectionately; with warm, tender feeling.

con anima — With soul; spiritedly, with feeling.

delicatissimamente — With the greatest delicacy.

ORNAMENTS & ARTICULATION

fioritura — Florid ornamental passagework; cascades of small notes decorating the melody, played with rhythmic freedom.

legatissimo — As smoothly and connected as possible; every note held to its full value.

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